Gurgaon literally means the ‘Village of the Teacher’. The Pandav capital of Indraprastha is said to be located under the Purana Qila in Delhi. Similarly, the site of Hastinapur is identified with a site near modern Meerut. The battlefield of Kurukshetra is nearby, in the state of Haryana. Farther afield, we have the cities of Mathura and Kashi (or Varanasi) which remain very sacred cities for Hindus.

Some of the Iron Age sites have been excavated, starting in the 1950s and have thrown up remains of ancient settlements. For instance, there is a strong traditional belief that Indraprastha was located on the same site as the sixteenth-century Purana Qila (or Old Fort) in the middle of modern Delhi. The site even had a village called Indrapat till the nineteenth century. Excavation between 1954 and 1971 found that there was indeed a major settlement here that dates at least to the fourth century BC. Pottery shards suggest there may be an older Iron Age settlement somewhere close by. Sadly, the exploratory excavation of Mahabharata sites of the fifties and sixties was not properly followed up in later decades.

One of the more intriguing Mahabharata-related sites is that of Dwarka in the westernmost tip of Gujarat. It said to have been founded by Krishna as his capital after he led his people from Mathura to Gujarat. Thirty-six years after the Kurukshetra battle, the city is said to have been devoured by the sea. Underwater surveys near the temple-town of Dwarka and the nearby island of Bet Dwarka have come up with stone anchors, a sunken jetty and elaborate walls suggesting the existence of an ancient port in the area. Although I am not entirely convinced by all of the claims made about the site, it is yet another reminder of how the forces of nature have directed the course of history [4] .

All this does not confirm the events of the Mahabharata, but it strongly suggests that the composers of the epic were talking about real places. Such findings are not unique to India. Till the nineteenth century, the places mentioned in Homer’s *Iliad* were considered to be mythical. However, Heinrich Schliemann’s excavations in the late nineteenth century showed that Troy and many of the places mentioned in the Greek epics were real places. Similarly, Chinese legends about the ancient Shang dynasty (1600-